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Ray Bryant

Pianist Ray Bryant was born to a musical family in Philadelphia on December 24, 1931. He gained valuable experience in his home town with guitarist Tiny Grimes and as house pianist at the Blue Note. Ray moved to New York in the late 50s and performed and recorded with Carmen McRae, Sonny Rollins, Jo Jones and numerous other jazz luminaries. "Little Susie" and "Cubano Chant" are among Ray's original tunes which became popular on his own trio recordings. He tours abroad frequently and enjoys a special status in Japan with fellow pianist Junior Mance. His most recent recording is "Ray's Tribute to his Jazz Piano Friends."

Ray was interviewed in New York City on March 22, 1998, by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: We are filming in New York City for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive and I am very pleased to have one of the most respected jazz pianists in music, Mr. Ray Bryant. Thank you for joining me.

RB: It's my pleasure to be here.

MR: I would like to read a little quote that was written about you from the *All Music Guide to Jazz*. The fellow said: "Although he could always play bop, Ray Bryant combines older elements including blues, boogie woogie, Gospel, and stride into a distinctive soulful and swinging style. No one plays 'After Hours' quite like him." Nice comment, huh?

RB: Yeah it's nice, especially since "After Hours" is one of my favorite tunes. I think it's one of the first piano selections that I actually learned. I learned it from the original recording by Erskine Hawkins, featuring Avery Parrish at the piano. I mean it's a composition of Mr. Parrish, and as I said it's one of the first tunes that I learned. And I've been playing it all my life and I still enjoy playing it.

MR: Can you tell me how you learned it? Did you learn it from listening to the recording, or did you get the sheet music to it, or was it a compilation?

RB: No I learned it just from listening to the recording.

MR: So you were listening to a large ensemble and bringing it down to the piano.

RB: Well the piano was featured in the orchestra. It was a feature piano thing. Actually it was like a trio recording right up until the very end of the tune, then the band comes in on the last chorus and plays a little riff behind the piano, and so it was basically a piano recording within the band, the Erskine Hawkins Orchestra. I really, really love this tune, and I finally, all my life it was a dream of mine to play this song with Erskine Hawkins, because you know I made a recording of it with Dizzy Gillespie and Sonny Rollins back around 1958, and the recording got to be pretty popular. A lot of people even accused me

of playing it better than Avery Parrish, which I never believed, never, not for a minute. So anyway, I was on a boat cruise, on a jazz cruise once and Erskine Hawkins' band was on the cruise also, and I met Mr. Hawkins and I just came out and asked him, I said, "Mr. Hawkins, I learned 'After Hours'" — he knew who I was, he knew that I wasn't just anybody, he knew that I could play — I said, "Could I come in and play this tune with the band one night?" He says, "Sure, come by tonight around ten o'clock and let me know you're there, and we're on." I did it and I played it with the orchestra, I knew the whole arrangement and everything else. It was one of the dreams of my life, came true.

MR: What a thrill. You came from a pretty musical city, Philadelphia.

RB: Philadelphia, yeah.

MR: A lot of great musicians including yourself came out of there.

RB: A lot of guys. A lot of guys, yeah. The Heath brothers, you know, Jimmy, Percy, Albert, Tootie; oh Lee Morgan, Bobby Timmons, Benny Golson. Benny and I sort of grew up together you know. And oh, McCoy Tyner, John Coltrane. It's just full of great musicians.

MR: Is there anything that distinguishes a musician from Philadelphia do you think?

RB: I don't think so. You know people say that you know, when you talk about — at least not anymore. Maybe at one time the music could be sort of like regional you know maybe, but now everything is so intertwined and it's so easily gotten together. The world's gotten smaller and there's no more Philadelphia sound or anything like that. It's said and maybe it's true that a lot of piano players come from Pittsburgh and like that, and a lot of piano players come from Detroit, and a few come from Philadelphia. But at one time maybe we thought that we could distinguish a certain sound as being from Philadelphia or Detroit, but not anymore.

MR: Well recordings are so prolific now that a young person can tap into music from anywhere now and get his influences that way I suppose. I understand your sister was a piano player also? A piano teacher?

RB: Oh she is. She still is. She still teaches piano and she is basically a Gospel pianist, about the best I ever heard. I haven't heard of anybody better than her. But she's a teacher and she's a piano teacher and Kenny Barron was one of her first students. I mean she was Kenny's first piano teacher. And we all know how great a pianist Kenny Barron is. My sister really turned one out there.

MR: So you came from a musical atmosphere in your home. Did you hear your sister playing as a young boy and aspire to it?

RB: Well actually my mother was the first, she was the main piano player there. My mother, who was a Gospel minister, she played the piano. She was the first one. And I was the first one to be sent to a formal piano teacher, and my sister started after I decided. So my

mother was the one that I actually heard play. And she said that the reason she sent me to the piano teacher was that she used to play something on the piano and then I would come along behind her and play something similar. She said this guy's got a little talent or something you know. She said maybe I better see what I can do with him. So she sent me to the piano teacher, and that's how I got started.

MR: Was it classical oriented piano at that time?

RB: Well when I went to the piano teacher it was classical instruction, really formal, classical instruction, which I feel stood me in good stead for the other things that I would want to do later on. There's nothing like having that classical foundation and background. You really learn how to play the piano and it just does you nothing but good.

MR: Did you have opportunities to play in the church then, being that your mother was a minister?

RB: Yeah but I didn't do it too much. I really didn't do it too much. I never by any stretch of the imagination considered myself a Gospel piano player. I just do not. There are influences which people say there are influences there and I'm sure that they are there, but that's about as far as it goes.

MR: In listening to you play, especially on this most recent recording we'll talk about along the way, I'm very impressed by the chording, the power of your left hand. It seems to me that you really like kind of chords in the two octaves below middle C, like kind of low sounding things, but they don't sound muddy the way you play them. Is that something that you consider part of your style or is it just my imagination?

RB: I guess so. I guess it would be a part of my style, yeah. I like to use the whole piano, but I try not to let one hand muddy up and destroy the other hand or something like that, try to get a balance in there. I figure that a piano is an instrument that you should be able to play alone. So and like I said the classical training helped in what I wanted to do with my left hand, as opposed to the right hand and so forth like that, and I guess it sort of evolved into some sort of a sound that was in my head that I had to get out of the piano. Through trial and error and so forth like that, the style evolved.

MR: Who are some of the first — you mentioned Avery Parrish of course and Erskine Hawkins. Were there other people that caught your ear as a young man, that directed you to jazz?

RB: Who were my main influences, I mean pianistically as far as I'm concerned, well I should say who did I listen to, who did I really like listening to was, number one would be Art Tatum. And Teddy Wilson. And then with the advent of the bebop era of course Bud Powell. And I think maybe a couple of horn players influenced my style too, like the linear things that I do, I think about Charlie Parker, with whom I had the great honor and privilege of playing with a couple of times.

MR: Let's talk about that. You became the house pianist at Blue Note?

RB: In Philadelphia, yes.

MR: In Philadelphia. And you were in your early 20s?

RB: Right.

MR: Was this a gig that was something that was a pretty good gig to grab?

RB: Well at that time I guess so. It wasn't much money to be made or anything like that, but as far as meeting people whom I heard only on records, it was just great and getting a chance to work with them. The Blue Note club, lots of guys came to play there without accompaniment. They came alone, and so it was up to the club to provide back-up for them, back-up musicians and I was lucky enough to be called in quite a few cases. I met — I can't even begin to say how many people I met as a result of being sort of like the Blue Note house trio. Charlie Parker was one, Sonny Stitt, Roy Eldridge, Charlie Shavers.

MR: Miles?

RB: Miles Davis. And as a result of the Miles meeting I even ended up making a recording with him, back in the 50s. That was the only one I ever did with Miles. And who else, oh Ben Webster.

MR: Coleman Hawkins perhaps?

RB: No, no, no, no. I didn't meet Hawk until I came to New York. And I got to play with him too and record with him two or three times because of a similar status that I enjoyed at Prestige Records. A record date, they would call me sometimes, once in a while, and the dates with Coleman Hawkins were wonderful, beautiful, wonderful.

MR: So as a house pianist, if the manager said to you okay — how much warning did you have, or I wouldn't say warning, how much time did you have before you knew a particular guy was coming to play, and did you feel you had to do some homework somehow to research the tunes that you knew that they liked to play? Or did you just have enough knowledge at that time where you could go in.

RB: Well I think I had the knowledge, because I of course listened to all their records. I had the records of Charlie Parker, and I listened to nothing but jazz recordings from guys at the time. And so like when I went in to play with Charlie Parker I knew all the tunes and he would just call out the key and set the tempo and we'd go.

MR: Was he personable to work with?

RB: Very personable. Yes. Charlie was a nice guy. I know he liked me. And we had a very good time together. As a matter of fact we were going to record together, because he said on my next recording session I want you guys. And he passed away.

MR: Who else was in that trio at that time?

RB: Specs Wright, a drummer from Philadelphia, Charles Specs Wright and most of the time Jimmy Rowser was the bass player. My brother Tommy played bass too, but he was doing other things at that time. So Jimmy Rowser was, most of the time, a part of the trio. And he's still around New York, he's still playing.

MR: Didn't your brother go on to play with a number of people, including the Ink Spots and —

RB: Yeah he did things like that. And he's on quite a few of my recordings of course, the trio things, the early trio things, and he's on the thing with Dizzy and Sonny Stitt and Sonny Rollins, things like that.

MR: A lot of musician genes in your family.

RB: Charlie Shavers and so forth.

MR: Did it come to a point where you felt you needed to go to New York? What prompted the move to New York?

RB: Oh yeah, yeah, yeah. I was in Philadelphia and Carmen McRae came to town without a piano player, and I went and filled in with her. And when she left I left with her. I was with her for maybe two years and I came back to Philadelphia, and then Jo Jones, of Count Basie fame, Jo Jones the drummer, he decided that he wanted to have a trio and he called me and I did that for a year, still based in Philadelphia. Then I got back from the thing with Jo Jones and I said I'm working only with people from New York and I know that's where I want to be, so why shouldn't I go there. So I did.

MR: And what year was that?

RB: Around '59.

MR: What was the jazz atmosphere in '59, at that time, 52nd Street kind of had come and gone.

RB: Yeah, right. Well I'll tell you when I first came here I did things like I would play in the afternoons at the Metropole, in the Metropole Cafe along 7th Avenue with guys like Charlie Shavers, Coleman Hawkins, Roy Eldridge, other guys who were playing there, Red—

MR: Not Red Nichols?

RB: No, a trumpet player.

MR: Red Rodney?

RB: No, no. no. He's more or less from the Dixieland era or something like that. I'll think of it.

MR: So many guys.

RB: Yeah but he was very — he had his own band there. I didn't play with him much but he was, the bands would alternate you know. And there was — avante gardists were going pretty good at that time. I mean at night time I played downtown at the Five Spot with

guys like Benny Golson, Curtis Fuller, like that. So I was very busy when I first came to New York, because I already knew most of the people, so it seems like when they found out that I was here I got busier than I could really handle.

MR: Was there a waiting period to get into the musician's union at that time?

RB: Yeah, there was. But I was already in by the time I got here because when I was a member of the Jo Jones trio, Jo saw that I gained membership status. And I've been a member all these years.

MR: Can I ask what the typical wages might have been like playing at the Metropole or the Five Spot?

RB: Well nobody got rich you know. I don't even remember. I guess I didn't even worry about how much money I was making you know. I guess I did not. I guess $125 a week maybe or something like that. Somewhere in that area, $100, $125 a week. But I was also busy doing recording sessions and that added on to the overall monetary figure.

MR: The typical recording session at that time, was it — did they usually give you a couple of days or a couple of sessions in the studio to complete an album?

RB: Yeah. Something like that.

MR: It was like a three hour session or something. Do you remember how that worked?

RB: Yeah. Maybe three hour sessions and maybe two days. If you needed an extra day you tried to have that set up too.

MR: What was your arrangement with the record label as far as, they pay you for the session and was that the end of it? Did you get money for albums sold?

RB: Well as far as a sideman that was the end of it, yeah. But if you were a leader and it was your recording session then you were supposed to collect royalties, but some of the record companies, you didn't always collect royalties. You were contracted and you were supposed to collect royalties, but I think most jazz musicians had problems with the recording companies back then. Guys just were not too honest. Hopefully it's changed a little bit now, but back then, the most you could hope for from, the most you could really rely upon from a recording session was that your record would be out there and get played and you might get some personal engagements from that.

MR: Right. It would be very hard for a musician to keep track of how many records they were selling.

RB: Right. And most guys were not that business-wise to know how to check on it or things like that. Record companies took advantage of it, a definite advantage of it, disgraceful in my estimation.

MR: Was there one record company that had a reputation as being good to work with, honest?

RB: Well I guess your best shot was to try to get with a big company. But no record company was beyond doing certain things. But the best shot would be to get with a big company.

MR: When you started putting your own trios together, I'm wondering when you started writing your own tunes, had that been something you were doing all along, or was it something that maybe when a record date opportunity came along that you wanted to then branch out and do your own?

RB: Well as far as writing my own tunes, that started long before I came to New York City and long before I got a recording contract of my own. You know I wrote a few tunes that were recorded by other people. George Shearing recorded a few of my songs, and Cal Tjader made the first recording of my tune entitled "The Cubano Chant," which is a pretty well known tune by now. But when I got my first recording contract, actually I made my first recording date under my own leadership, under my name, was around '55, long before I left Philadelphia to come to New York. I did a recording session for Epic Records in conjunction with Betty Carter, Betty Carter, the singer, that was my first recording session and also her first, because we had the same manager, John Levy. He got us this recording date, and on that I recorded two of my original things you know. But this was long before I got to New York. Of course after I came to New York I really tried to get a trio together, a working trio, which wasn't until around 1960. That's when we recorded "Little Susie," and things like that. And even "The Madison Time" the dance, the song you know.

MR: Oh yeah. Probably hard to keep a working group together for a long stretch of time given the nature of the business.

RB: Yes, yes. It was pretty rough yeah, but I did okay for a while there because the records achieved a lot of public acclaim and got to be pretty popular. They used to call them hit records or something like that. "Little Susie" really did very, very well. So I had a trio together for a while. But then things changed and I just sort of went out on a freelance thing, like whatever I could do. Of course today I don't even try to keep a trio together because more and more I just do solo piano things. That's what I've been doing more and more, most lately. Once in a while if a trio is called for, such as this latest recording here, I call the best guys that I know and try to get them in there.

MR: I have to admit to overhearing part of a conversation last night, after the concert, that you were having, and all I heard was you said to this woman that you only play in New York a couple of times a year. So other than that, you're like moving around?

RB: Yeah. Well for a while, like back in the '80s, I played only in New York. You know I had maybe three or four clubs that I just played like two or three weeks at a time, and I kept it going on a rotating — and it took up the whole year. So I found that I wasn't getting a chance to go and play anyplace else. So I had to really just stop it, cut it out, and since then it's gotten to the point now to where, like you said, I only play maybe two weeks a year in New York City. The rest of the time I'm out of the country, or doing other things.

MR: Going back to, you were talking about "Little Susie," did you have a sense when you recorded that tune that, you know I think this tune's really going to do well for us? Or does it sometimes come as a real surprise that one particular thing hits and the others don't?

RB: Well I wasn't surprised at this because we had tried it out on so many audiences before making the record. I mean actually I recorded it with the Jo Jones trio when I was with Jo. It hadn't really evolved to what it ended up being like when I did it under my own name in 1960, or the last part of '59. But having played it in so many clubs and joints around, and seeing the reaction of the people to this tune, I knew that if we ever got a chance to put it down on a record, the way that it had evolved to be, it would probably do very well. And that's the way it turned out.

MR: Interesting. Sonny Rollins you've played with, Betty Carter. Is it different playing behind singers than horn players?

RB: Well I always approach it the same way, the same way. I would say to me it's not too much of a difference because I feel like whether I'm playing for a horn player or for a singer, my role is to support, and wherever I can embellish. So I do the same thing for a horn player that I would do for a singer in regards to that. So I don't see too much difference in playing. I mean some guys do it differently, but my approach would be the same for a singer as for a horn player. If a horn player is playing a ballad, I do the same thing I would do basically if a singer were singing this same ballad. So I approach them similarly.

MR: Is it a problem sometimes, or a challenge, when you have to play perhaps the same tune but if you're playing it with a vocalist, a tune you've played many times, all of a sudden it's in a new key?

RB: Oh this can be a problem, but it shouldn't be — I guess I'm fortunate it's never been a big problem for me. Most anything I can play I can play in almost any key. It doesn't make any difference.

MR: I should explain to our listeners eventually, that I got to see you play last night with the Marian McPartland tribute which was a wonderful event. And when Sweets Edison came out, and I think you did a couple of numbers and then you were going to do "Centerpiece," and Marian was at the other piano. And I saw you do this to her, you know? It was very deliberate that you were showing her something. Can you explain what that's about?

RB: Yeah, let me explain. Marian was actually joking, she said well "Centerpiece," that's one of the tunes that we played, that's the tune that we played when Marian came out. It's a Sweets' original. Sweets Edison original. I played it with him many times before. Anybody knows it's in the key of A flat. So Marian was just joking, she said, "What

key?" And so I said [gestures] which means four flats, key of A flat. So we were just joking back and forth and having some fun.

MR: Right. I like that. What do you do for four sharps though?

RB: Let's see what key is four sharps? Four sharps, I don't know.

MR: It would be the key of — yeah right. Okay. For four sharps I'd go, no thank you.

RB: That would be the key of E.

MR: The key of E yeah. Unlikely to be playing in the key of E with a horn player.

RB: You know we don't delve too deeply into the sharp keys. Most jazz tunes are in flat keys.

MR: I just think that's so interesting to be on the stage at Town Hall, and the way jazz musicians work, you just go like this. Can you imagine Pavarotti coming out and going to his accompanist, you know.

RB: Four flats.

MR: Jazz certainly has its own language, and it's marvelous to see veterans working together, that they've all done it so many times. They can be in a New York venue like that and pull it off. It's great. I know you've traveled overseas quite a bit.

RB: Yes.

MR: The Japanese in particular seem to really enjoy jazz. You go over there once a year or—

RB: Well at least once a year generally. Sometimes there have been years where I've gone three times within one year. But generally maybe once or twice a year I do solo tours over there, and the last maybe five or six years there's been a production, a Japanese production over there, called One Hundred Gold Fingers, and they bring over ten of us. Ten piano players on the same show. And it's very successful in Japan. I don't know really how well it would do over here in the United States. But the Japanese promoter has been thinking about it, because it's really been successful over there. And then I go do a festival once in a while or something like that. Or I go over just to record once in a while. But I've been to Japan many, many times and it's a good place to go and play jazz. People really love it. I look forward to going back again.

MR: A friend of yours, Junior Mance, told me to ask you about the Blues Brothers.

RB: Well within this production, the One Hundred Gold Fingers, you get to play duets, you know you play your solo piano, you play duets with other people. Marian did it once with us, she went over one year. The roster varies, they change it around from year to year. But I've been on every one every year, I've been on every one, Junior has too. So I guess it was inevitable, in the pairing up of different piano players like playing duets, Junior and I would end up together at least. So we did it once and we played the blues and the reception was so great that pretty soon Junior and I sort of found ourselves together most of the time, and we played the blues. And so that's why the Blues Brothers. They started calling us the Blues Brothers.

MR: Is it possible to put into words what is so attractive — I don't know if that's the right word — but the blues just seems to grab people. Have you ever been able to understand why that is?

RB: Not really. I guess it was one of the — it was the first form. Blues, and then jazz. It was definitely one of the more common harmonic structures for jazz tunes. It goes all the way back to the St. Louis Blues, Bessie Smith, and it was definitely a production of the black culture here in the United States, it's the blues. And jazz I guess — the main players of this music were black people, and it's just like the blues is like the music of our people. It's infectious, everybody likes the blues, but nobody wants to have them.

MR: Has jazz been instrumental in helping the racial scene in this country?

RB: Oh to no end. To no end. If they'd just let everybody listen to the music and have fun, there probably wouldn't be half the problems that we have been experiencing. And there have been times like when it seemed to be going that way, like back in the 30's and 40's, everybody went up to Harlem to hear music. Everybody got together at night time to hear music. I don't know what happened. I guess the uprisings and the riots and things just sort of kind of negated that kind of get togethers and so forth. So what may have happened was sort of stopped right in its tracks. But even so in spite of all these setbacks, I would say that yes, jazz music has been totally instrumental in bringing the races together, and everybody really gets together and do something together, we're going to listen to music together. We don't have time to fight. We listen to music together — do something constructive.

MR: What about the scene today? Do you think that there's any — is the music still able to do that today or is there kind of two different—

RB: Yeah they're still able to do it. It still does what it can. I had occasion, I just came back from Paris a few weeks ago. And I was playing at a club over there in Paris. And in the middle of my concert, an American white woman got up in the audience and said, "You make me proud to be an American." I thought that was very nice. So you see.

MR: Gosh. You really reached her, didn't you.

RB: Yeah. It really made me think that was a nice thing for her to say and it meant something.

MR: They seem to respect the music pretty well overseas, don't they.

RB: Yeah. Oh yeah.

MR: Has there been an occasion where your music has been affected by anything going on in rock & roll or the popular market? Something that you've really liked for instance, whether it's using electronics or that you said, yeah, I could use a little of that?

RB: Well I might not exactly use it, but sometimes something strikes my ear. I mean you hear all the time and once in a while I hear something coming from another idiom that I like. In the first place, I like music, period. I like music. The only two types of music that I

really don't care for, one is Hawaiian and the other is country & western. But there have been times when I've even gotten something out of one of those idioms. I just pick it out and it gets to my ear and I like it. But let's face it, music is music. It's only one, two, three, four, five, six, seven, eight, nine, ten, eleven notes or something like that, twelve, twelve different notes. And it's all made up from these twelve notes, no matter what it is. So there has to be some relationship there, there definitely has to be.

MR: I guess there's good and bad, right?

RB: Yeah.

MR: Did you ever have an occasion to record with electric piano? A Fender Rhodes or—

RB: I think maybe one time I did that. It was never my thing.

MR: Didn't do it for you.

RB: No. Not my thing.

MR: You have such a strong attack, I don't know if the instrument could handle it.

RB: Well you know there's no similarity in the electric piano and the acoustic piano. The only similarity that I see is the construction of the keyboard. Other than that it's an entirely different thing. Your attack is different between acoustic and electric. You can't put too much of your own personality into it. Everybody sounds about the same on it you know.

MR: When you look back on your career from, oh gee, your early days in Philadelphia up until now, was there a stretch of years that's been the most difficult because of the market for jazz for you?

RB: Well each year is different. I got — the leanest years, one of my leanest years was for me, was back maybe back in the mid-60's or something like that. There was a time when there just wasn't too much happening. Maybe it was just for me, or it could have been for the rest of the industry, I don't know. But I got through it. As I say you stick to your guns, and like I say well I'm going to do this and I'm not going to do anything else, and things brightened up again. Basically I've not had too much of a problem throughout my entire career. And I'm happy to say that things right now are better than ever. These are the great years for me and I'm finally able to do more or less what I really want to do, which is play the piano, play the piano.

MR: Glad to hear that. Let's just talk a little bit about your most recent recording here. You picked out an impressive list of piano players to pay tribute to and interpret their music. And you know I remember early in the interview you were talking about some people commented on how they thought you played "After Hours" better than the original. And I have to say that that may be the case for a couple of tunes on this record also. That your version of them is really is quite outstanding.

RB: That's nice to hear, thank you.

MR: I'm not sure I can put this into words, but when I listen to some of the differences from the original recordings and yours, you have a really unique way with the melody. And you seem to put in little pauses in certain places where the original artist may not have done it. Is that something that you think of or is that just my own—

RB: Well I haven't been too conscious of that, but I guess to even want to record a song I have to sort of like feel to a certain extent that even though I didn't write this song, I have to sort of like take over a little bit, and think of it as being a part of my — how can I put this — I have to put my own personal stamp on it, even though it's not my tune. But if it catches my ear and I think enough of it and I get to like it enough that I want to make a record of it, then it's going to take on parts of my own personality. I guess this is unconscious.

MR: I guess maybe what I'm hearing too is you choose to not sustain some notes in the melody where the original artist did, and it gives it a little bit more staccato effect or something.

RB: Yeah, that could be.

MR: Okay. I wanted to play one little section of C Jam Blues, and just ask you about something that happened at the end of one of the choruses here.
[audio interlude]

MR: Now, what I wanted to ask you is when you got to bar 10 or whatever, and you kind of hung on that one chord there, whatever that chord was, was that something that was planned? And did the bass player know it was coming? Or was it just one of those kind of things that happened spontaneously?

RB: No, that was planned. Because that's an arrangement. Yeah, he knew it was coming.

MR: That was basically my question, because I'm always fascinated by when things like that happen, was it something you had an opportunity to say okay when this part comes—

RB: No he knew that was coming. See that's like a piano arrangement. I try to play the piano like it's a big band you know, and bring in different sections, brass and so forth. So more or less it's played basically the same each time. But it's a piano arrangement so he definitely knew that that was coming.

MR: It worked well. You like to work in solo settings?

RB: And that chord was a D flat chord.

MR: Thank you. I could tell it was something that really wanted to resolve itself eventually and it works great. Is that the format with this particular trio that you like either trio or solo context to work in these days?

RB: Yes. And once in a while just duo, maybe just piano and bass. Like I said I play in New York about twice a year and we played like the Sweet Basil club here, towards the end of the year in the fall we played there and then maybe once during the summer. At the

Sweet Basil I used piano, bass and drums. But then there's another room here that I enjoy playing in maybe once a year and it's called the Club Zinno. The Zinno Club. And when I go there I use just the bass fiddle.

MR: Who's the first five people you call for bass players, for a gig like that?

RB: Well these days, Ray Drummond, who was on this recording, I was lucky enough to catch him for this, Ray Drummond, Rufus Reid, Jimmy Rowser, when he can make it, Jimmy Rowser is still playing, Paul West.

MR: That's a name I don't know, but I trust he must be pretty good if he's on your A list.

RB: And that's about four. There are more that I can't think of right now.

MR: Sure.

RB: If I need a trio, I guess one of the first drummers I would call would be Winard Harper. He's on this recording also. I was lucky enough to get two of my first choices. I was very happy, happy with the way that the recording turned out, and I also use them, I get them — for the Sweet Basil engagement, I call them well in advance to be sure that I can get them or somebody like them.

MR: And a job like that, if you have a week or something at Sweet Basil's, are you able to rehearse with those fellas, or do you just work enough together that you can pretty much go in and—

RB: Well we don't work together that much see, because like I say I vary some of them. I don't take a trio anywhere basically. I go just as a soloist and so if I get something like this generally we can manage to get together just to become re-acquainted, or maybe run over some new stuff that I might want to do, maybe one or two rehearsals before the engagement, depending on the availability of them to make these rehearsals. So maybe one or two times.

MR: It was interesting to hear a completely acoustic version of Joe Zawinul's tune, "Birdland."

RB: Oh "Birdland." You know this recording came about because a fellow over there at JVC Records, Larry Hathaway. He called me one day about a year ago, I think it was about a year ago, he said, "Ray, I want you to make a record for us." I said, well first I said I don't know, I don't think I need another record right now. And he says why. And I said well lots of my old things are being re-released on CD and so forth, and I've been recording pretty regularly for a Japanese label and so forth, and I said if I don't make any record right now it's fine. I'm okay right now. So he was very persistent, and he kept calling and calling. So finally I said okay. And then it was his idea to do this tribute to my piano friends. It was his idea. And so they said can you think of some guys that might want to do this about? And so I'll have some suggestions too and so between the two of us, this is the final list that we came up with. And "Birdland," Joe Zawinul's "Birdland,"

of course the popularity, the thing is to do a tune that each guy either wrote or was associated with and made popular, like that. Of course in the case of Ramsey Lewis, like "The 'In' Crowd" it was one of his biggest things you know. In the case of "Birdland," that was Joe Zawinul's really huge popular tune with Weather Report. So one of the problems with that was trying to put it into a trio context and make it sound like it has got a sound. It had that effect. I think we got that.

MR: I think you did too.

RB: It's turned out to be one of my favorite cuts on the CD.

MR: I've heard that tune done in so many ways, everything from marching bands and now a jazz trio. And I suppose we could say that it's become a standard. And I'm always curious as to try to guess what tunes are being written now, or in the last ten or fifteen years, that will become standards, as most of our standards have come from the '40s, '30s. Are they being written now? New ones?

RB: Well I don't know. Some of the new things I heard are pretty — I guess they could be. But I listen to some of the new stuff and some it's like shocking. Harmonically they've gone really, with the modal things and so forth, which I don't really delve into. Some of them I like and some I'll say well I don't know. Interesting, things that they're doing these days. I don't know how long lasting they may end up being, that just remains to be seen. But we're not going to see to many "Take the A Train"'s or "C Jam Blues" I don't think so.

MR: Can you look at your career and pick out some really fond memories right now? Recording sessions or just particular nights where the group of musicians you were playing with was very just really outstanding? Is that possible with all the playing you've done over the years? Can you think back and say boy, I'm so glad that one happened?

RB: Well I've had some outstanding nights, memorable nights, as a soloist and in some trio settings too. As a soloist my most memorable nights would be my first time in Europe ever. And I was called to play the Montreux Jazz Festival in Switzerland, that was my first time ever in Europe and I was doing a solo. I think that, I'm trying to remember who was on that night, I think they had maybe three or four different artists on that night, I think Stan Getz, Stan Getz's group was playing, and I think Chuck Mangione's group was playing, and me, solo. I mean I knew these guys you know, so when they saw me they said who's with you? I said nobody. Are you kidding? I said I'm going to play solo. Okay. And I started to play. After they had played then it was my turn. And I was a little nervous or apprehensive or whatever, but after maybe a half a tune I realized that the audience was definitely with me. And it turned out to be one of the most enjoyable nights of my career.

MR: You could just feel that kind of electricity?

RB: Oh yes. And as luck would have it, Atlantic Records was recording that night and I was an Atlantic artist at the time, and they were recording "Alone at Montreux" came from that. Then on the basis of this record people around the world just liked this record, with the audience and everything, the audience participation, the applause and so forth. It turned out to be a great record for me, and as a result of that I was able to go on and play many places in the world that I might not have been able to.

MR: Yeah. It was a good night then. One of the things I read about you happened to mention a night, the Newport Jazz Festival in 1957, and they went so far as to make a note of a solo that you played on, let's see you were with Coleman Hawkins and Roy Eldridge. "I Can't Believe That You're In Love With Me." They mentioned that you really ripped it up on that or something.

RB: Really?

MR: Yeah.

RB: I don't remember. It's been a long time since I've heard that record. I'll have to check it out.

MR: You'll have to go and see what you did on that. See if the audience was with you that night too. Well this has really been fascinating talking to you, and I'm so glad that we got to hear you last night. You just said that you're not in great need of putting out a new record, but I hope you do soon.

RB: Well I probably will because the response to this one has been great, and I'm pretty sure that I'll be doing something as a follow-up to this.

MR: Probably another trio setting?

RB: Most likely another trio setting, yes.

MR: Where are you off to — I'm sorry to interrupt you.

RB: A Tribute to My Piano Friends Volume II.

MR: Are you off to any distance soon, traveling?

RB: No, I'm in the middle of a sort of like a late winter-early spring vacation you know, just being around home. The thing last night for Marian was the first thing I've done in maybe three weeks, so I'm just kind of taking it easy. I had a very, very busy winter. I spent almost a month in Germany and two weeks in Paris and I was in Japan in December, and I've really been moving around, and so sometimes you just have to sit still and just enjoy, and that's what I'm doing right now. I think my next thing out of the country would probably be I have some festivals to do this summer in Europe and in Canada, the Ottawa Festival I'm going to do and I think the Toronto Festival and there's a possibility of festivals in Wales, JVC Festivals in France again, and I'm supposed to go to Italy sometime this year, and a club date in Switzerland and things like this, but nothing in the near future, in the next couple of weeks.

MR: When you have three weeks off, are you a practicer?

RB: Not too much, but I'm a little more than I used to be because I just bought a new piano just before Christmas.

MR: I was going to ask what's your preference in pianos?

RB: I bought a Steinway. Steinway is, that is my preference. So I'm playing this one pretty good, but I'm not a diligent practicer like three or four hours a day, no. I just sit down and play something, I get up and go and come back to it later. I keep it open so all I've got to do is sit down and play.

MR: Well thanks so much for your time. It's been a pleasure talking to you.

RB: It's been my pleasure being here with you.

MR: Best of luck with your travels.

RB: Thank you very much.

MR: Appreciate it.